

Walden University

College of Management and Technology

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Walden University
2019

PREVIEW

Abstract

Workplace Isolation Occurring in Remote Workers

by

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MBA, Walden University, 2015

BA, Hiram College, 2012

Dissertation Submitted in Partial Fulfillment
of the Requirements for the Degree of
Doctor of Philosophy
Management

Walden University

May 2019

Abstract

Organizational leaders and managers may not have the management acumen, organizational awareness, or leadership expertise to construct and implement effective strategies, policies, and procedures to help reduce the frequency of the phenomenon of workplace isolation. The purpose of this qualitative, exploratory, multiple case study was to gain a common understanding about how workplace isolation may influence a remote employee's performance in a customer service organization in the United States.

Emerson's social exchange theory was used as the conceptual framework. A series of semistructured interviews with 21 remote workers that consisted of 4 different divisions at the same organization was conducted to yield thematic results. Data analysis included holistic and pattern coding. The most common understandings that emerged into themes were the need of social interaction, manager communication, and peer-to-peer interactions that had an influence on job performance. The knowledge acquired in this study can affect social change by providing insights for leaders, managers, and practitioners to create policies and strategies to improve the engagement, performance, and well-being of remote workers who may experience workplace isolation.

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Dedication

I would like to dedicate my work to my children, Elliana, Benjamin, and Nina. No matter what anyone will say to you, if you want something in this life, wait for no one and go get it. Always hold yourself to the highest standard of what you can contribute, and do what you do best every day. To my wife, Alecia, thank you for your endless hours given for me to finish this dissertation and your support along the way.

PREVIEW

Acknowledgments

To express my gratitude for my chair, Dr. Richard Schuttler, may require another dissertation. Dr. Schuttler provided guidance, encouragement, and equipped me with the knowledge I needed in the times of writing this dissertation. Learning Dr. Schuttler's incremental gains philosophy provided the encouragement to always continue on in each chapter of this dissertation. I would like to also thank my committee member, Dr. LaBrina Jones, for always being supportive, present, and able to assist regardless the question. Thank you both for your time, support, and mentorship.

I also want to acknowledge Dr. Joe Streur and Dr. Vanessa Camilleri. Dr. Streur, friend and colleague, helped me think about this dissertation topic before starting this journey and was a mentor on just about all aspects of this journey. Dr. Camilleri was my accountability partner. She may never know how her words of encouragement pushed me through this process. Thank you both for answering my questions, listening to me vent, and always being a great friend.

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PREVIEW

Chapter 1: Introduction to the Study

Introduction

Remote working is a strategy whereby an organization's employees work off-site. When working remotely, the employees can experience workplace isolation that could disengage them from their work and ultimately disrupt their performance and well-being (Collins, Hislop, & Cartwright, 2016; Marshall et al., 2007). Environmental surroundings, such as office space and other aesthetics in an office, can influence the performance of a remote worker, and physical and mental aspects of working remotely may help or hinder a remote employee's performance (Choi, 2017).

In this qualitative, exploratory, case study, I focused on remote employee workplace isolation. The purpose of this study was to gain a common understanding about how workplace isolation may influence a remote employee's performance in a customer service organization in the United States. The insights gained through this study may influence strategies and policies that could provide managers and leaders with information on how a remote employee who has experienced workplace isolation is impacted both mentally and physically. With certain changes made by managers and leaders, the social aspect of a remote worker's experience could change, which may benefit their career as well as their health while in this remote position.

Background of the Study

Employees can experience workplace isolation when working remotely (Marshall et al., 2007). Current academic literature about remote working has been published about how manager and employee personality differences, working conditions, the influence of

well-being when working remotely, and autonomy can impact performance (Orhan, Rijsman, & Van Dijk, 2016). Previous research has provided findings about the implications of workplace isolation on remote workers' performance (Dolan, 2011).

In this study, the performance of a remote worker was considered the measurement of three dimensions: (a) individual tasks behaviors, (b) team member behaviors, and (c) the behavior of the remote employee as perceived individuals in the organization. Ajzen and Fishbein (1977) explained that the theory of planned behavior aspects known as attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavior control are contributors to the intention of behavior change. Applying this theory to the topic at hand, this means that if a remote worker fails to have a progressive mindset and has an environment that does not allow them to thrive and perceive that they can excel, the remote employee will have a decline in their performance. In their study on remote working performance among salespeople and supervisors, Mulki and Jaramillo (2011) found that as remote workers became more isolated from their peers and manager, their performance and satisfaction about their job decreased.

Another aspect of how workplace isolation can influence a remote worker's performance is through the well-being of the employee. When exploring factors of well-being as a remote worker, the notion of emotional experiences may be considered. Furthermore, scholars have investigated the emotional dimension of positive behaviors and found that remote workers report a more positive affective well-being than a negative affective well-being on the days of working remotely (Anderson et al., 2014). Health indicators, such as obesity, depression, stress, tobacco use, alcohol abuse, poor nutrition,

and physical inactivity, may be experienced by workers when working remotely (Henke et al., 2015). These indicators have been observed through a longitudinal study of remote workers determined that working remotely can yield health risks, and one indicator was the intensity of working remotely (Henke et al., 2015). In sum, the more an employee works remotely, the higher the risk of the discussed symptoms (Henke et al., 2015). Henke et al. (2015) found that employees who worked greater than 8 hours per month were significantly less likely than those who worked in an office to experience depression. In contrast, Solis (2017) reported that employees who did not work remotely were at greater risk for obesity, alcohol abuse, tobacco abuse, and physical inactivity.

The results of these types of studies provide context to managers and leaders as to what the impact can be on remote workers when working remotely. In this study, I explored literature related to remote employees who have experienced workplace isolation or are currently experiencing workplace isolation and how this may impact their performance. With findings from this type of qualitative research, managers and leaders may begin to gain new insights into remote working and start implementing changes to improve their employees' working conditions and well-being.

Problem Statement

The general problem was that corporate managers who lead teams with remote employees may not have the management acumen, organizational awareness, or leadership expertise to construct and implement strategies, policies, and procedures to help reduce workplace isolation (see Day & Burbach, 2015). Workplace isolation is a situation when a remote worker experiences the belief of being ignored, which could

influence their performance and overall well-being, increase loneliness, and may lead to social and emotional deficiencies (see Marshall et al., 2007). Basile and Beauregard (2016) studied ways to create successful remote working boundaries between work and home and found an implication between setting boundaries between the remote worker's autonomy and control over experiencing isolation. Boundaries such as strategies to stay connected to peers and their manager. Studies like Basile and Beauregard's continue to provide literature for managers, leaders, and practitioners that may only produce insights into workplace isolation and not the affect it has on a remote worker's job performance.

The specific problem of workplace isolation was that when this situation occurs, remote workers may experience a decrease in their performance on the job. In the United States, 43% of employees work remotely (Gallup, 2017). Literature about remote working has associated isolation with the volume of work the employee has as their level of responsibility will influence the risk of employee isolating themselves to get their work completed. Duxbury and Halinski (2014) hypothesized that the relationship between hours per week required to meet their job demands and stress would be moderated by the number of hours the remote worker would spend in an isolated state. The survey data these researchers collected from 1,806 male and female professionals provided evidence that autonomy to get their work done was more critical to the employee than being able to work from home in an isolated location.

Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this qualitative, exploratory, multiple case study was to gain a common understanding about how workplace isolation may influence a remote

employee's performance in a customer service organization in the United States. In semistructured interviews, I asked open-ended questions of a sample of 21 remote workers, that worked in four different divisions in the company, who were in customer service roles to gain an in-depth understanding of the influence workplace isolation had on their performance. The four divisions within the organization each provided more than four employees from the sectors of business development, software engineer, talent development, and product management. To achieve a multiple case study perspective, each of the four groups of remote workers was considered as its own case study. Then I combined the aggregate data for reporting the common understandings and themes generated from all of the interviews.

Qualitative data from the interviews provided me with the situations and lived experiences of the participants to be synthesized and discussed as results to adequately describe their thoughts and beliefs of being isolated and how workplace isolation can diminish job performance. I also sought other sources of data from the organization's recorded artifacts (see Marshall & Rossman, 2016). These recorded artifacts were policies, procedures, and other documentation that represented two specific items related to a remote workers performance: (a) any documentation that pertained to how the performance of a remote worker was evaluated and (b) any workplace policies or strategies for managing a remote worker.

Research Question

What are the common understandings about how workplace isolation may influence a remote employee's performance in a customer service organization in the United States?

Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework for this case study was grounded in the social exchange theory (Emerson, 1976). Social exchange theory is dependent on a two-sided, mutually dependent, and mutually gratifying exchange involving communication of some sort or simply a conversation (Emerson, 1976). According to Emerson's (1976) theory, a social exchange would need to occur between remote workers and their employing organization to preserve a remote employee from experiencing workplace isolation. This conceptual framework allowed me to link the qualities of social exchange between a remote worker and in-office worker that is absent in workplace isolation. Emerson's social exchange theory also supports the missing human needs of an individual who is experiencing workplace isolation. Researchers have applied adaptations of Emerson's social exchange theory in studies related to workplace isolation that helped managers learn successful management strategies to work with remote workers (Greer & Payne, 2014; Shankar et al., 2017). Greer and Payne (2014) explained that the more technology is used, the more supervisors are accessible, and the more employees communicate, the more the risk of overcoming remote working challenges will be avoided. Emerson's theory provided the context for grounding this study with the idea of the missing elements of human interaction, known as the social aspect of remote working.

Nature of the Study

For this study, I employed a qualitative research method. According to Yin (2018), qualitative studies focus on an individual as the sample of interest. In this study, the sample included multiple interviews of individuals in groups in which each individual served a different function in the same organization and had experienced workplace isolation as a remote employee. The qualitative research method was appropriate for studying workplace isolation occurring among remote employees based on the need for their thoughts, beliefs, and meanings for improving remote working and overall consistency in remote working performance to address the research question.

A quantitative research method would have been able to provide a conclusion that the problem of workplace isolation exists and determine what variables are objective when studying this situation (see Patton, 2016). I did not choose this method because quantitative research does not allow flexibility within the interview process. In a mixed-method study, the focus is on the lived phenomenon as a quantitative measurement and understanding the perspective of the phenomenon as a qualitative measurement (Patton, 2016). I did not choose a mixed method design because of the discrepancies between each data type.

Keeping the focus on how remote workers are missing the elements of social exchange theory may provide context to epistemological expectations of human needs as a remote worker (see Emerson, 1976). According to Englander (2018), case studies cannot be used to develop or refine a theory; instead, a multiple-case study experiment can give rise to research that provides new insights and potentially applies to new cases

studies in the future. A case study design was appropriate for this study because it allowed me to focus on workplace isolation within the framework of social exchange theory. The results of this qualitative analysis will build on the literature related to workplace isolation and advance the thinking in the practice of management.

Grounded theory research provides context from data by the participants involved in the study (Johnson, 2014). A grounded theory was not the appropriate design for this study because I was not attempting to ground the method with the results of this study. Phenomenological researchers seek to provide the experiences of an event or concept through the study of multiple participants (Englander, 2018). A phenomenological design was not appropriate for this study because I wanted to arrive at a common understanding amongst participants and artifacts in the study to be able to contest the results.

Definitions

Flexible working: An option provided by the organization to allow the employee to determine their schedule and place of getting work completed (Bentley et al., 2016).

In-office worker: An employee with a dedicated workstation at a company location where he or she completes the demands of their job (Groen, Triest, Coers, & Wtenweerde, 2018).

Performance: A process that contributes to individuals and teams to achieve tasks associated with the job description (Solis, 2017).

Remote worker: An employee who works at home or somewhere other than a permanent desk in an office provided by the company (Allen, Golden, & Shockley, 2015).